Q What does edX have for the Indian market?

Ours is a non-profit organisation and a learning website, where anybody can come and learn for free. We have around 900,000 students from India, and in total more than eight million students from all around the world. The share of the Indian market is about 11 per cent, and India is second only to the US, which accounts for 30 per cent of our students. Therefore, India is a gigantic market for us.

The reason why Indians are very exciting is that the courses we have are quite useful and in demand worldwide. For instance, as computer science is very popular in India, you can take a fantastic course based on computer science simply using our online platform. You can choose introductory programming from Harvard or MIT, right from our website. Likewise, you can take some advanced courses related to frameworks like Ruby on Rails from Berkeley, or basic courses to learn about computers such as an introduction to computer science from IIT, Bombay.

“At edX, we not only offer courses for free, but have also made the online platform available for free as well.”

Apart from computer science, we have courses for data science, which is another hot area. Whether it is data analytics, business analytics or the analysis of data, we have many job-oriented data science programmes on edX. These are from Columbia, Microsoft, and so on.

We also have business and language courses (such as learning to write well and business English), which are very popular on our platform. We have also launched a course on TOEFL preparation. This new programme comes directly from ETS, which is the organisation that offers the TOEFL exam, and lets students prepare for TOEFL for free.

Many students are taking these courses and getting jobs all across the globe. It is hard to find these courses locally in India but, with a platform like edX, anyone with a computer and an Internet connection can join them and nurture their career.

Q What are the main challenges in maintaining an online course platform?

We are non-profit, and we make career-oriented courses available for free. Offering a free course is quite challenging, because it costs a fair amount of money to maintain and run a course. We have to pay the hosting fee to a hosting provider like Amazon. Also, each course has a faculty member and teaching assistant who answers questions on the Q&A forum.

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Therefore, our biggest challenge is to generate sufficient revenue to sustain and make the courses available to the public.

Q Does using open source solutions help edX solve the challenge of generating revenue?

We don’t take money from venture capitalists because if you do that, you need to deliver a return on the investment in a short span of time. It is hard to get a massive return on investment when you are giving things away for free. At edX, we not only offer courses for free, but have also made the online platform available for free as well. This includes the platform software as well as some analytic tools and mobile apps that are all available for free to the world.

To maintain the integrity of the platform and offer free services, we do several things. We use the open source community to improve many of our existing features. A large number of people from the open source community are providing support, contributing back to the software base and helping us quickly improve edX. So that is a huge win for us.

Apart from utilising the power of the open source community, we launched a new programme last year to translate courses into credit. Called MicroMasters, the initiative allows you to get an online credential from Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT). If accepted to the on-campus master’s programme, the credential converts directly into the one-semester worth of credit. Now that MOOCs translate into the credit from top universities like MIT, we have to build features into the platform to maintain the integrity and prevent instances of cheating. So we’ve integrated many mechanisms to restrict cheating practices. Numerous open source ecosystem partners are also building some advanced systems that are helping us solve some big operational challenges.

Q Why was there a need to launch Open edX, when you already had edX in the space of MOOCs?

EdX uses a platform software, and we could just leave edX for the public. However, many people suggested that rather than developing software from scratch, we could share our software. So we introduced Open edX. This lets anybody take our code and launch their own website for education.